

Spoken into Reality: God's Sovereignty in a Designed Universe

Introduction

If God is the Author and continual Sustainer of reality, how should we understand the stability of creation—and His ability to intervene within it?

The Bible presents God as both the Creator and Sustainer of everything that exists. He did not merely bring the universe into being and then step away from it. Scripture declares that Christ is “*upholding all things by His powerful word*” (Hebrews 1:3), that “*all things were created through Him and for Him*” and that “*in Him all things hold together*” (Colossians 1:16–17), and that “*in Him we live and move and have our being*” (Acts 17:28).

Creation is therefore real, orderly, and dependable—but it is not independent of God.

The regularity we observe in creation is what we call *natural law*. The sun rises, seasons follow seasons, gravity operates consistently, water flows downhill, and the physical world behaves according to patterns that can be observed, tested, and described. Science is possible precisely because creation displays this remarkable consistency.

Yet the consistency of creation does not mean that God is bound by the patterns He established.

The God who ordinarily sustains creation according to consistent laws is also capable of acting within His creation in ways that transcend those ordinary patterns. Scripture calls these events miracles. They are not evidence that reality has ceased to be real or that creation has somehow broken down. Rather, they demonstrate that the Creator remains sovereign over the creation He sustains.

This raises an important question: *If God normally sustains creation through consistent patterns, how should we understand His ability to intervene within those patterns?*

One modern analogy that can help us think about this is the concept of a “*divine simulation*.” But the analogy must be handled carefully. Scripture does not teach that the universe is a simulation, and the word itself can suggest something artificial, unreal, or merely virtual. None of those ideas is intended here.

Creation is real. Human beings are real. Our choices and experiences are real. God's intervention in history is real.

The point of the analogy is much narrower. It attempts to illustrate the biblical truth that creation is completely dependent upon God and that its continued existence rests upon His sustaining will.

If the analogy helps illuminate that truth, it can be useful. If it obscures the truth, it should be discarded.

The reality itself does not depend upon the analogy.

It depends upon God.

1. God Is the Author of Reality

The opening words of Scripture establish the foundation: “*In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.*” — Genesis 1:1.

Before there was a universe, there was God. Before there were stars, planets, oceans, mountains, or human beings, God existed.

Creation therefore does not explain God. God explains creation.

Everything that exists apart from God is dependent upon Him for its existence. John writes, “*Through Him all things were made, and without Him nothing was made that has been made.*” — John 1:3.

The universe is therefore not self-originating and self-explanatory. It has an Author.

And like a written story, creation possesses order because its Author has given it order.

But the analogy of an author has limits. God did not merely write a story and leave it on a shelf. Scripture presents Him as continually involved with what He has made.

2. God Is Not Merely the Creator—He Is the Sustainer

Hebrews gives us one of the clearest statements: “*The Son is the radiance of God’s glory and the exact representation of His nature, upholding all things by His powerful word.*” — Hebrews 1:3.

God did not simply create the universe and leave it to operate independently. He continually sustains it. Paul says of Christ, “*He is before all things, and in Him all things hold together.*” — Colossians 1:17.

The regularity we observe in creation reflects God's sustaining faithfulness. What we call *natural law* describes the consistent way God ordinarily upholds the world. The universe is orderly and intelligible because it is not independent of its Creator.

3. Stability Does Not Mean Independence

There is an important distinction between *stability* and *independence*.

Creation is stable. Creation is not independent.

The predictable patterns of nature allow us to study the world, make discoveries, and live within it with reasonable confidence. Yet those patterns do not sustain themselves. Scripture declares that God gives humanity *“life and breath and everything else”* (Acts 17:25), and *“In Him we live and move and have our being”* (Acts 17:28).

The consistency of creation should therefore produce confidence in God's faithfulness, not confidence in creation's independence.

The universe is dependable because its Creator is dependable.

I think this is substantially better for the paper. It eliminates the repeated explanations while preserving the two ideas you need:

Section 2: *God sustains reality.*

Section 3: *The stability of reality does not mean it is independent of God.*

4. God Is Not Bound by the Patterns He Established

If God ordinarily sustains creation according to consistent patterns, does that mean He is incapable of acting differently?

No.

The Creator is not subject to the creation.

God established the order of nature; nature did not establish God.

Jeremiah declares, *“Oh, Lord GOD! You have made the heavens and the earth by Your great power and outstretched arm. Nothing is too difficult for You!”* — Jeremiah 32:17.

This is where miracles become important.

A miracle is not necessarily a violation of reality. It is an extraordinary act of God within reality.

The ordinary patterns of creation tell us how God normally sustains the world.

A miracle reveals that God is not restricted to those ordinary patterns.

From our perspective, they are miracles; from God's perspective, there are no miracles—only the exercise of His sovereign authority over the creation He made and sustains.

5. The Sun Standing Still

Joshua records one of the most extraordinary events in Scripture: “*So the sun stood still and the moon stopped until the nation took vengeance upon its enemies. Is this not written in the Book of Jashar? ‘So the sun stopped in the middle of the sky and delayed going down about a full day.’*” — Joshua 10:13.

Whatever precise physical mechanism God used, the biblical point is unmistakable: God intervened in the created order.

The event does not require us to conclude that creation ceased to be real. It demonstrates that the Creator has authority over creation.

From the perspective of ordinary physical experience, the event appears impossible. From the perspective of God's sovereignty, it is an extraordinary act of the One who created and sustains the physical world.

We do not know precisely *how* God accomplished it.

Scripture does not tell us.

But Scripture does tell us *who* accomplished it.

And that is the essential point.

6. Jesus Calms the Storm

The same principle appears in the ministry of Jesus.

When a storm threatens the disciples, Jesus rises and says, “*Peace! Be still!*” — Mark 4:39.

And the wind ceases.

The response of the disciples is significant: “*Who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey Him?*” — Mark 4:41.

They understood that something extraordinary had happened.

Jesus had not merely predicted a change in weather.

He commanded the storm.

The One through whom creation came into existence demonstrated authority over creation itself.

The miracle therefore points beyond the miracle. It reveals the identity of Christ.

John explains the purpose of Christ's signs: “*Jesus performed many other signs in the presence of His disciples, which are not written in this book. But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God.*” — John 20:30–31.

Miracles are not merely interruptions in nature.

They are revelations of the One who rules nature.

7. Miracles Do Not Make Reality Less Real

This distinction is important.

If a miracle occurs, we should not conclude that reality has been suspended or that the world has become unreal.

The opposite is true.

A miracle demonstrates that reality is larger than our ordinary experience of it.

We know only the patterns God ordinarily permits us to observe. We do not know every possible way God can act within His creation.

Our scientific descriptions are descriptions of observed regularities. They are not boundaries placed around God's power.

Science can tell us how water ordinarily behaves. It cannot tell God how water must behave.

Science can describe gravity. It cannot impose a law upon the Creator.

Science can observe the regular movement of the heavenly bodies. It cannot prevent the One who made them from acting within His creation.

This does not make science meaningless. Quite the opposite. Science studies the remarkable consistency of the world God has made.

Miracles remind us that the consistency of creation should never be confused with the limitation of its Creator.

8. A Modern Analogy—Used Carefully

This is where the modern concept of a “*divine simulation*” can provide a useful, though limited, illustration. The analogy comes from something familiar to the modern mind: computer programming.

A programmer can create a complex environment governed by countless variables. Once those variables are established, the system operates according to consistent patterns. Yet the programmer remains capable of changing those variables and producing an immediate change in the system without destroying the system itself.

That provides a limited illustration of how we might think about miracles. What appears impossible within the ordinary patterns of creation is not impossible for the One who established and continually sustains those patterns. God does not merely operate *within* creation—He is its Creator and Sustainer.

The analogy, however, has definite limits.

God is not a programmer, the universe is not a computer, and creation is not artificial or virtual. Human beings are not digital characters living inside a larger computer system. Scripture does not teach any of these things.

The analogy is useful only in this limited sense: **a created system can possess genuine order and consistency while remaining completely dependent upon the one who established and sustains it.**

A human programmer can change a variable within a system he has designed. God is infinitely greater. He created the system itself—the matter, space, the temporal order, and the physical order within which we live—and He continually sustains it.

Therefore, when God intervenes in creation, He is not violating an independent authority called “natural law.” He is exercising authority over the creation whose ordinary patterns we describe as natural law.

The programming analogy is only a window through which the modern mind may glimpse a biblical truth. Scripture is the foundation, and the reality behind the analogy is infinitely greater than anything human technology can create.

9. Human Beings Are Part of God's Purpose

This understanding of reality also changes how we view ourselves.

We are not accidental observers trapped inside a meaningless universe.

Scripture says, *“For we are God's workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life.”* — Ephesians 2:10.

Human life has purpose because its Author has purpose.

Yet this does not mean that human beings are meaningless machines following predetermined instructions.

God gives human beings genuine responsibility.

Moses records God's invitation: *"I have set before you life and death, blessing and curse. Therefore choose life, so that you and your descendants may live."* — Deuteronomy 30:19.

Our choices matter. Our decisions have consequences. Our obedience matters. Our disobedience matters. Our response to the gospel matters.

The fact that God sovereignly sustains reality does not make human responsibility meaningless.

It makes our existence purposeful.

10. God's Sovereignty Does Not Eliminate Human Meaning

If God is sovereign over reality, does that mean our lives are merely scripted?

Scripture does not require that conclusion.

The Bible presents God's sovereignty and human responsibility together.

Joseph's brothers acted wickedly when they sold him into slavery. Yet Joseph later told them, *"As for you, what you intended against me for evil, God intended for good, in order to accomplish what is now being done, the saving of many lives."* — Genesis 50:20.

The same event involved genuine human evil and genuine divine purpose.

This is a mystery, but it is not a contradiction.

God's sovereignty does not make human choices meaningless. Instead, it assures us that human choices cannot ultimately overthrow God's purposes.

Paul writes that God works *"according to the plan of Him who works out everything by the counsel of His will."* — Ephesians 1:11.

History therefore has direction.

It is not a collection of meaningless events.

God is accomplishing His purposes within it.

11. Reality Points Beyond Itself

Scripture also teaches that the world we presently experience is not the final reality God has promised.

Paul writes that *“the creation waits in eager expectation for the revelation of the sons of God”* (Romans 8:19) and that creation itself will be *“set free from its bondage to decay and brought into the glorious freedom of the children of God”* (Romans 8:21).

The present creation is therefore real, but it is not final.

Likewise, Scripture describes earthly realities as shadows and copies of greater realities. Paul writes, “These are a shadow of the things to come, but the reality belongs to Christ.”—Colossians 2:17.

Hebrews describes earthly worship as *“a copy and shadow of the heavenly things.”* — Hebrews 8:5.

This does not mean the physical world is unreal.

It means the physical world is not the end of the story.

What we see points toward what God has promised.

12. The New Creation

The biblical story ultimately moves toward restoration, not escape from reality.

John writes, *“Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth, for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away.”* — Revelation 21:1.

God does not simply abandon His creation.

He renews it.

John hears the declaration: *“Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man, and He will dwell with them. They will be His people, and God Himself will be with them as their God.”* — Revelation 21:3.

The final hope of Christianity is therefore not that believers will discover that earthly existence was merely an illusion.

It is that God will bring creation to its intended fulfillment.

There will be no more death, mourning, crying, or pain.

The God who spoke creation into existence will bring His redemptive purposes to completion.

13. What This Means for Us

If God is the Author and Sustainer of reality, several truths follow.

We can trust the stability of creation because its regularity reflects God's faithfulness.

We can believe in miracles because God is not limited by the ordinary patterns through which He sustains creation.

We can trust God's purposes because history remains under His sovereign authority.

We can take human responsibility seriously because God has given human beings meaningful choices.

We can endure suffering because present circumstances do not represent the end of God's story.

And we can look beyond the present creation toward the promised new creation.

Paul captures the proper perspective: *“For our light and momentary affliction is producing for us an eternal glory that far outweighs the affliction.”* — 2 Corinthians 4:17.

What we see is not all there is.

What we experience is not the whole story.

And what God has promised is greater than what we presently understand.

Conclusion

If God is the Author and continual Sustainer of reality, then the stability of creation should not lead us to think that creation is independent of Him.

It should lead us to recognize His faithfulness.

The regularity of nature reflects His sustaining will.

The existence of the universe reflects His creative power.

Miracles reveal His authority.

Human responsibility reflects the significance He has given to human beings.

And history moves toward the fulfillment of His purposes.

The concept of a *“divine simulation”* is not biblical terminology, and it should never become a doctrine. It is only a modern analogy—an attempt to communicate the deeper biblical truth that everything that exists is completely dependent upon God.

Perhaps a better way to express the idea is simply this:

We live in a real world, created by a real God, sustained by His power, governed by His purposes, and ultimately destined for His glory.

The universe is not autonomous.

It is not accidental.

It is not abandoned.

It is *upheld*.

“For from Him and through Him and to Him are all things. To Him be the glory forever! Amen.”
— Romans 11:36.

That is the reality behind the analogy.

And that reality does not depend upon our ability to explain it.

It depends upon God.